

2008 NEWSMAKER THE TERRORIST

The terrorist returns to the becomes too profane, worthy of annihilation

him; we seem to know him. He is one of them. The most recognisable one. The terrorist we are getting familiar with.

The word is almost worn-out, and its banality is accentuated by its recurrence. Terror, terrorism, terrorist—the dictionary tells us that the words are rooted in fear. Extreme fear evoked by rage, violence, fantasy and hate. The professional with terror as his calling card pictures himself as freedom's last warrior, guided by gods and ideology, and accessorised by wares of death, preferably death in a spectacular backdrop. His definition of freedom, though, excludes the essential dignity of what he calls the enemy and what the rest of us see as humanity. The recesses of our cruellest yesterdays are filled with the legends of his madness; and in the iconography of history, his synonyms are many: revolutionary, crusader, assassin... Terrorist is a rebel with a nihilistic fury, and whose vision of liberation is hell for the other. In the last century, terror at its sanguineous worst was ideological, and it was a necessary condition for the creation of the empires of the working class. The Great Terror of Stalin, institutionalisation of the gulag, Cultural Revolution of Mao, the killing fields of Pol Pot, ethnic cleansing in the Balkans, the Baathist horror chamber that was Saddam Hussein's Iraq (aptly described as the Republic of Fear by an exiled dissident writer)—they were all extreme manifestations of revolutionary instinct. And remember: every revolutionary begins as a romantic, triumphs as a liberator and rules as a terrorist.

Around the time the god of ideology began to fail in the Soviet block, the god of the Book joined the freedom struggle in Persia. The Great Islamic Revolution of Iran was the 20th century's first introduction to faith-in-power. It was a war against modernity and it signalled the restoration of the absolutism of religion. It inspired the street fighters of Islam, whose ascent in the post-communist world spawned a new age of fear, for the ambition of radical Islamism too was extra territorial. The Sword of Islam would become more than a metaphor. On September 11 in 2001, the rage of religion would reach its zenith, literally, and the flames that melted down the twin towers of the World Trade Center would magnify the new mas-



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cot of terror. Osama bin Laden, the Saudi billionaire-turned-Islamic "liberator", looked like a bearded mountain god with a Kalashnikov in that videotape, and his commandments, delivered from Mount Jihad, were a declaration of war against infidels: "America is struck by Almighty God in one of its vital organs, so that its greatest buildings are destroyed... America has been filled with horror from north to south and east to west, and thanks be to God. What America is tasting now is only a copy of what we have tasted. Our Islamic nation has been tasting the same for more than 80 years, of humiliation and disgrace, its sons killed and their